Chapter 24

Small-minded People in Big Positions: Insecurities Galore

'OFF WITH HER HEAD,' THUNDERED THE MINISTRY OF HOME Affairs one fine May morning in 1995, and promptly Kiran found herself occupying the office of the deputy commissioner of police, Vigilance Branch, at the Delhi Police Headquarters. This, of course, was to be a very temporary position because her new office, as additional commissioner of police, planning and implementation, was yet to be physically made since this charge had never been an independent one to date. Probably because of the effectiveness with which Kiran had brought about reforms in the almost hopeless Tihar Jail, the commissioner of police, Delhi, Nikhil Kumar, entrusted her with the task of 'planning for the Delhi Police to be the Police of the 21st century'. She would be required to draw up a master plan whereby the duties of the Delhi Police could be placed in their proper perspective and its administrative and operational infrastructure could be matched. Better late than never, one should rightly think, although it apparently took the single-minded and determined efforts of a single officer in the field of prison reforms to bring about this new turn in reforming the Delhi Police.

However much such a change in the force may have been required and however much it may have been justified that the force got just such an officer whose talents were suited for this purpose to a T, the manner in which the entire affair was handled left a very bitter taste in the mouth. And, therefore, one attempts to draw certain conclusions.

Kiran's posting as IG (Prisons) had, at the outset, been apparently a 'dump' posting because from September 1992 to April 1993 the Home Ministry had been quite seized of the problem of having a police officer of the union territory cadre whiling away nine months in Delhi without any assignment. Tihar Central Jail appeared to be the ideal place to 'dump' this officer. To the acute discomfiture of her seniors, Kiran's work created a high profile for her even in this 'punishment' posting. Yet, again, she dared to stand up to the powers that be and instead of snivelling and grovelling as was expected of her by them, she flung the Magsaysay Award and the Nehru Fellowship at them. Not content with just this, she made her work in Tihar so transparent that the outside world came to know about the tidal wave of correctional reforms that were taking place there. And the work was impressive enough to catch the people's imagination not only in India but also abroad.

The Government of the United States of America was impressed enough for the Congressional Committee of the US Senate to invite her for a Prayer Breakfast with President Bill Clinton and his wife Hillary Clinton. The United Nations Organization was impressed enough with her achievements to invite her to Copenhagen, Denmark, to attend the United Nations World Summit for Social Development (6–12 March 1995). The British Foreign Office was impressed enough to have the British High Commission invite her to visit the prisons in the UK.

Kiran's superiors, however, were not impressed! When the world was watching the dramatic way